INDIANA

The Hoosier State



Before Indiana had highways or headlines, it had farms. Miles of them, black-soiled and flat-horizoned, spread across glacial plains that the last Ice Age had spent millennia leveling and enriching. That land drew settlers west in the early 1800s, carrying their tools, their faith, and their recipes alongside everything else they owned.

They arrived in a territory that became a state in 1816, and built their lives the hard way: clearing timber, breaking sod, planting crops in soil so fertile it felt almost unfair. Corn came first, then wheat, then hogs raised on the leftover grain. Settlements grew into towns along the National Road, the country's first federally funded highway, cutting straight through Indiana's heart. Towns like Centerville, Greenfield, and Indianapolis rose along its muddy corridor, and with them came the kitchens and cookstoves where women fed families through planting seasons and harvests, through bitter winters and the long hungry stretch before the first crops came in.

It was in those kitchens that Hoosier Pie was born—claimed by no single woman, owned by no single county. It belonged to all of them. The pie grew out of "desperation pies," a tradition born from necessity and perfected by ingenuity: when fruit was out of season and the root cellar ran low, farm wives reached for what they always had on hand—eggs from the hens, butter churned that morning, sugar from the crock on the shelf, a splash of vinegar to cut the sweetness, a handful of cornmeal or flour to hold it together. Poured into a lard crust and set in a wood-fired oven, the filling baked into something quietly miraculous: custardy at the center, set at the edges, a thin crackled top giving way to rich, dense sweetness underneath. Every community that settled Indiana adjusted the recipe in its own way, and called it their own.

By the time county fairs took hold in the latter half of the 1800s, Hoosier Pie was already a fixture on the dessert table—judged, compared, debated, and eaten in quantities that suggested Hoosiers took both their baking and their opinions about it seriously. The Indiana State Fair, established in Indianapolis in 1852, became a stage where farm women displayed a year's worth of practice and pride, and a perfectly executed Hoosier Pie—golden, uncracked, trembling just slightly at the center—was a ribbon worth working for.

The pie outlasted the wood-fired stoves it was born on. It survived the shift from farm kitchens to suburban ones, from lard crusts to store-bought shells, from cane sugar to whatever was on sale—because at heart, it's a forgiving, generous recipe that asks very little and returns something deeply satisfying every time.

When you make this pie, you're taking part in something that stretches back two centuries and across thousands of Indiana kitchens. No special occasion required, no hard-to-find ingredients—just a bowl, a crust, and a few things you almost certainly already have. The result is the kind of dessert that silences a table in the best possible way—the kind someone asks about before they've finished their first slice.

HOOSIER PIE

Rich, golden, and unmistakably Hoosier, this is the pie Indiana built itself on, and once you taste it, you'll understand exactly why.

Yield: One 9-inch pie

INGREDIENTS

CRUST

- 1 (9-inch) single pie crust, homemade or store-bought
- 1 Tbsp whole milk (for brushing)

FILLING

- ¾ cup granulated sugar
- ¼ cup packed light brown sugar (for old-fashioned caramel depth)
- ¼ cup cornstarch (thickens the custard—no eggs, the classic Hoosier way)
- ¼ tsp salt
- 5 Tbsp unsalted butter (browned, for deeper flavor)
- 2¾ cups heavy cream (use the best you can find; it's the star)
- 2 tsp pure vanilla extract
- ⅛ tsp freshly grated nutmeg

SNICKERDOODLE TOPPING

- 2 Tbsp unsalted butter, melted
- 2 Tbsp granulated sugar
- 1 tsp ground cinnamon
- Pinch of freshly grated nutmeg

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Blind-Bake the Crust*: Adjust the oven rack to the lower-middle position and preheat to 400°F (204°C). Roll out the pie dough and fit it into a 9-inch pie plate; flute the edges and brush the rim and bottom with the whole milk (this waterproofs the crust so it stays crisp under the creamy filling). Line with parchment and fill with pie weights or dried beans. Bake for 15–16 minutes, then remove the weights and parchment and bake 7–8 minutes more, until the shell is fully baked and lightly golden. Set aside to cool.
2. *Whisk the Dry Base*: In a large bowl, whisk together the granulated sugar, brown sugar, cornstarch, and salt until no lumps remain. Whisking the dry ingredients thoroughly first is the key to a lump-free, silky custard.
3. *Brown the Butter*: In a heavy-bottomed saucepan over medium heat, melt the 5 Tbsp butter and continue cooking, swirling the pan, until it foams, smells nutty, and turns a light amber with browned flecks, 3–5 minutes. Watch it closely at the end—it goes from browned to burnt quickly. Pour it into a small bowl and set aside. This nutty, caramelized butter is the upgrade that lifts this pie above the plain versions.

4. *Cook the Custard*: Gradually whisk the heavy cream into the dry ingredients until completely smooth, then whisk in the browned butter. Transfer into a saucepan and cook over medium heat, whisking constantly and reaching into the corners of the pan, until the mixture thickens and large bubbles break the surface, 6–8 minutes. Once it boils, keep whisking for 1 full minute more so the cornstarch fully activates and the filling will set firm. Be patient and don't stop whisking—constant motion prevents scorching on the bottom, which would ruin the delicate flavor.
5. *Finish the Filling*: Remove from the heat and immediately whisk in the vanilla and grated nutmeg until fully incorporated. Pour the hot filling into the baked crust and gently jiggle the pan to level the surface. Let it rest and set for 15–30 minutes while you prepare the topping.
6. *Broil the Snickerdoodle Topping*: Move an oven rack to about 6 inches below the broiler and set the oven to broil. Drizzle the melted butter evenly over the surface of the pie, tilting the pan to cover it completely. Stir together the sugar, cinnamon, and nutmeg in a small bowl, then sift it evenly over the buttered top. Broil for 1–2 minutes, watching every second, until the sugar melts, bubbles, and caramelizes into a thin snickerdoodle crust. Don't walk away—it can scorch in seconds.
7. *Chill and Serve*: Cool the pie to room temperature on a wire rack, then refrigerate until completely cold and set, at least 4 hours or overnight. The filling will look like loose pudding when warm and firm to a sliceable custard as it chills. Serve cold or at room temperature, dusted with a little extra nutmeg if you like. Like most old-fashioned cream pies, it's even better the next day.

ILLUSTRATION PLACEHOLDER

Hoosier Pie — finished dish illustration

Food only (finished dish, ingredients or preparation) — no people